Emma Gordon

Curriculum Vitae

✉ *Emma.Gordon@gsi.uni-muenchen.de*
My Webpage
Github *Linkedin*



Education

2022–2027 **PhD, Comparative Political Science (submission expected March 2027)**, *Ludwig Maximilian University of Munich*, Munich.
Dissertation: *The Small State Exception: Democracy, Breakdown, and the Politics of Size*. Supervisor: Prof. Dr. Nicole Bolleyer. Focusing on democratisation, democratic breakdown and exclusion of self-governing non-state territories and small states.

2020–2024 **Graduate Diploma in Arts, Endorsement in Economics**, *Massey University*, New Zealand.
Equivalent to Bachelors major in Economics. Part-time study to complement political science knowledge. Courses include: Macroeconomics Policy and Applications, Competition and Industry, Survey of International Economics, Development Economics.

2020–2021 **Master of Arts, Political Science and International Relations**, *University of Canterbury*, Christchurch, NZ.
Master by thesis with distinction (A grade). Thesis researching the effectiveness of small states in WTO dispute settlement mechanism. Conducted fieldwork in the form of expert interviews.

2019–2020 **Bachelor of Arts (Hons), Political Science and International Relations**, *University of Canterbury*, Christchurch, NZ.
GPA: 7.75/9 (approximately 1.4). Dissertation discussing impacts of small state involvement in regional trade agreements (A grade).

2016–2019 **Bachelor of Arts, Political Science and International Relations, German as a second language**, *University of Canterbury*, Christchurch, NZ.
GPA: 7.43/9 (approximately 1.5). Courses: Comparative Politics, Foreign Policy, International Political Economy, Militarism, European Integration. Semester exchange at Albert-Ludwigs-Universität Freiburg.

Research

Job Market Paper

2026 **Gordon, E. R.**, *"The Statehood Problem: Selection Bias and Exclusion in Democratic Transition Research"*, Under review.

Shows that case coverage in the literature is significantly lower than claimed, and that the resulting exclusion of small states and self-governing non-state territories constitutes a selection bias with material consequences for existing findings. Replicating three studies with up to 50 additional cases yields a partial resolution of long-standing empirical ambiguities around modernisation theory and new evidence on the mechanism underlying regional diffusion effects. Importantly, it proposes that the statehood criterion for inclusion should be replaced with a self-governance criterion.

Under Review & Working Papers

2026 **Gordon, E. R.**, *"Small Democracies Don't Die: Population Size and Democratic Breakdown"*, Under review at Comparative Political Studies.
Establishing and investigating the phenomenon of reduced likelihood of democratic breakdown in small democracies and proposing a theoretical mechanism.

2026 **Gordon, E. R.**, *"Selection into Democracy: Beyond the Transition Paradigm"*, In preparation.
Examining why small polities are more likely to select into democracy rather than transition to democracy.

Datasets

2026 **Small State Coverage Project (SSCP)**, *Harvard Dataverse*.
Extends standard cross-national datasets to the 224 states and fully self-governing non-state territories they routinely exclude. Released: fractionalisation and oil and gas wealth (up to 39 added polities, including corrections to the base data). In preparation: conflict, colonialism, contiguity, population, and democracy data.

2026 (forthcoming) **Self-Governance and Sovereignty Dataset (SGS)**.
An original dataset identifying sovereign states and fully self-governing non-state territories in existence between 1800 and 2026 (visualised here). Release pending publication of related work.

2026 (in development) **GDP Coverage Tool**.
A flexible tool for constructing maximum-coverage cross-national GDP (PPPUS$) datasets by combining user-selected base datasets and base years. Designed for researchers who need the widest possible country coverage, such as those studying small polities, and replication. Research note in development.

Presentations

Conference Presentations

2026 Presented the work-in-progress paper *"Small Democracies Don't Die: Population Size and Democratic Breakdown"* at the IPSA 2026 WiPS session.

2024 Presented the work-in-progress paper *"Patterns of Exclusion: Uncovering Selection Bias in the Democratic Transition Literature"* at the IPSA 75th Anniversary Conference (Democratization and Autocratization panel).

Departmental Presentations

Dec 2026 "Selection into Democracy: Beyond the Transition Paradigm," Research Colloquium, Geschwister Scholl Institute for Political Science, LMU Munich.

July 2026 "Small Democracies Don't Die: Population Size and Democratic Breakdown," Research Colloquium, Geschwister Scholl Institute for Political Science, LMU Munich.

May 2024 "Patterns of Exclusion: Uncovering Selection Bias in the Democratic Transition Literature," Research Colloquium, Geschwister Scholl Institute for Political Science, LMU Munich.

Teaching Experience

Democratisation from a Comparative Perspective

SoSe 2025 and 2026 **Course Instructor**, *Ludwig Maximilian University of Munich*.
Designed, taught, and assessed an undergraduate course on why states democratise and why others don't in different countries across historical time periods.

Democratic Development and Stability in Germany

WiSe 23/24, 24/25, 25/26, 26/27 **Course Instructor**, *Ludwig Maximilian University of Munich*.
Designed, taught, and assessed an undergraduate course on the development and stability of German democracy since unification.

Small States in the International System: A Comparative Perspective

SoSe 2022, 2023, 2024 **Course Instructor**, *Ludwig Maximilian University of Munich*.
Designed, taught, and assessed an undergraduate course exploring the unique perspectives, challenges, and advantages of small states in the international system.

Academic Positions

April 2023–present **wissenschaftliche Mitarbeiterin (Research and Teaching Associate)**, *Geschwister Scholl Institute for Political Science*, LMU Munich.

SoSe 2022 **Lehrbeauftragte (Adjunct Lecturer)**, *Geschwister Scholl Institute for Political Science*, LMU Munich.

Academic Service

2024 Served as panel discussant at IPSA 75th Anniversary Conference, Democratization and Autocratization panel.

2024/25 Mentor, Year of Study in Munich Programme: provided local guidance, organised group activities, and offered one-on-one academic advice to American exchange students.

Language Skills

Languages English: Native, German: B2, Mandarin Chinese: HSK 1

Methods Skills

Quantitative Methods Large-N cross-national and panel-data analysis; logistic, probit, and rare-event (Firth) regression; fixed- and random-effects panel models with clustered standard errors; event-history/duration models (Cox, discrete-time hazard); marginal effects and bootstrapped predicted probabilities; original data collection via web scraping, dataset construction and harmonisation

Qualitative Methods Semi-structured elite interviews (WTO ambassadors, trade officials, international legal practitioners)

Programming / Software R (Intermediate), Stata (Intermediate), Python (Basic)